

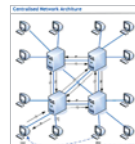
## Successor To Centrino Due this month

Intel said it would officially release its next mobile platform, Napa, in January. Napa is equipped with the powerful Yonah dual-core processor. Intel claims Napa will boost average performance 68 per cent beyond the Sonoma platform, while extending battery life beyond the 5-hour mark.



## Legal P2P In A Set-Top Box

MuViBOXX!, a new entertainment company, introduced the world's first legal P2P media centre in a set-top box. The box will feature biometric DRM, and allow consumers to download movie and music content from a proprietary global file-sharing network. The box has a 500 GB hard disk.



# Enter

### Rahul Bose

Actor and Director

Rahul Bose gave up an illustrious advertising career only to emerge as a prolific actor, director and script writer. After a successful debut as Agastya Sen in *English August*, he went on to write and direct the critically acclaimed film *Everybody Says I'm Fine*, and endeared himself to audiences through his role in *Mr and Mrs Iyer*. Rahul discusses his tech quotient with *Digit*:

#### What role does technology play in your life?

Technology has helped me enhance my creativity. Whether it is acting, theatre, or writing scripts for that matter, technology gives you a distinct advantage. For instance, I use Final Draft—software to write film scripts.

#### What gadgets do you own?

I own a Motorola V3 phone, an iPod Nano, and an Apple Mac at home—nah, that's not because I am partial to Apple or anything, but I guess I've really gotten used to the Mac.

#### What do you mostly do online?

I surf the Net, e-mail and blog. The one site I frequently blog on is Intentblog.com. It's a platform for people to develop a dialogue about new paradigms in creativity, communication, and fulfillment.

#### Any instance where technology really helped?

When I was in the tsunami-hit Andamans, it was the Internet that helped me stay connected with the rest of the world.

## WILL THE \$100 LAPTOP TAKE OFF?

# Mere Gadget Or Affordable Laptop?

Will the \$100 laptop change the world? Will it at least positively impact some students in developing countries? Opinion is divided. Even as Taiwan's Quanta, the world's largest manufacturer of notebooks, signed on to the project, Intel's chairman dismissed it as a mere "gadget".

The pedigree of the \$100 laptop is impeccable. It's been designed by industry specialists at MIT in co-operation with the One Laptop Per Child (OLPC) association, and was first conceived by MIT Media Labs founder Nicholas Negroponte. The project itself is very ambitious, aiming, as it does, to empower every child with a laptop. Even the UN has expressed support for the idea that cheap laptops will be an effective way to spread computers across the world.

The response from the media, governments and the industry has been fantastic. Orders for millions of units have been received from governments in Brazil, Egypt, Thailand and Nigeria. Negroponte unveiled the design of the device in November last year, and plans are underway for the first units to be shipped early in January '06.

Given this background, what are we to make of Craig Barrett's remarks? Intel's chairman openly criticised the concept. At a press conference in Sri Lanka, he insisted there will not be a market for the devices.

Barrett argued that a computer's features are more important than price. He claims that the laptop is an ineffectual gadget that

that has the full functionality of a PC, reprogrammable to run all the applications of a grown up PC... not dependent on servers in the sky to deliver content and capability to them, not dependent on hand cranks for power."

So what does the "gadget" feature? The CPU is 500 MHz; the colour/monochrome dual-mode screen is 7.5 inches diagonally; there's 128 MB of RAM, 512 MB of Flash memory, and there's 802.11b wireless support. Two speakers and four USB ports are provided. There's no hard disk, optical or floppy drives. On the software front, the laptop runs Red Hat Linux, and incorporates a Web browser, a word processor, an e-mail program, and a programming system that includes the Squeak programming language.

The most obvious explanation for Barrett's remarks is the fact that in August, Intel opened four platform design centres in Brazil, China, Egypt and India, to design computers for local markets. So are we to entirely dismiss Barrett? Perhaps, perhaps not. History has shown that attempts to bring computers to the poor are likely to fail. There have been several attempts, without success, to bring low-cost PCs to Brazil. Then there's the Simputer,



will suffer from low demand and limited success despite huge international interest in the project. Citing hardware limitations, Barrett said that the \$100 laptop will not adequately meet the needs of its target consumers and that Intel's contributions to IT in developing countries are far more tangible and relevant:

"Mr Negroponte has called it a \$100 laptop—I think a more realistic title should be 'the \$100 gadget.' The problem is that gadgets have not been successful. It turns out what people are looking for is something

